

Handhelds aren't easy

Nintendo and Valve dominate handheld gaming, and a lot has to do with the fact that they define it. Any company arriving in 2025 is walking into a market where the rules are already written by two very different and effective incumbents. Nintendo's Switch family, with the Switch 2 looming in the public consciousness, owns the living room to backpack pipeline through hybrid design and irresistible first party games. Valve's Steam Deck turned the PC library into a portable habit, combining credible performance with openness and constant software polish. That is the benchmark, and it is a high one.

Nintendo wields an advantage few tech brands can replicate. A large global installed base, a trusted family friendly image, and first party IP that sells hardware. The Switch proposition looks simple on the surface, play anywhere with minimal fuss, but the underlying execution across hardware, operating system, and content curation is the point. Valve's proposition is different, yet just as compelling. Steam is already the centre of gravity for PC gaming purchases. The Deck made that library portable with a tuned Linux stack, verified badges that set expectations, and a community that embraces tinkering without making tinkering mandatory.

A newcomer must match baseline expectations on ergonomics, thermals, battery life, input quality, and display fidelity. That demands top-tier silicon partners, deep firmware work, robust thermal design, and long test cycles. Miss on any one of these and word of mouth will punish you. Even if you hit the numbers on paper, sustained performance and reliability under varied climates and power conditions matter more than a one-off benchmark. Repairs and spares also enter the equation. If a joystick module or battery is hard to source or expensive to replace, trust erodes quickly.

Nintendo's operating system is fast, consistent, and built around friction-free switching between handheld and big screen. SteamOS is a moving target that gets better every quarter, from input layers to game compatibility to sleep and resume stability. Repli-



“A new device has to offer something players feel instantly — not just a better spec sheet, but a better experience.”

Mithun Mohandas
Managing Editor



Let me know your thoughts on this column at:
@mithun_mohandas | mithun@digit.in

cating that level of integration requires years of iteration, not months. A new entrant that leans on generic desktop builds, minimal controller layers, or a rough storefront will ship a poorer user experience, even if the hardware looks impressive. Then there is content. You cannot buy Nintendo's exclusives on any other platform. You also cannot instantly graft the social proof of Steam wishlists, reviews, cloud saves, and controller layouts onto a new store. Without a strong library strategy, either through partnerships, cross-platform compatibility, or a layer that improves how existing games run on your device, you are asking customers to compromise.

Consumers trust Nintendo and Valve because their products work, support is reachable, and software updates keep arriving. Building trust takes multiple region launches, consistent after sales service, and transparent return and repair policies. Distribution is expensive and dull work, yet it is a moat. So is pricing discipline. Incumbents have costs that benefit from scale. To compete on price while maintaining quality, a challenger needs either a subsidy strategy or a very carefully scoped bill of materials. The worst place to be is premium pricing with a first generation product and no ecosystem upside. And that's exactly what all the new entrants from big-name brands are doing.

The path is not closed, it is simply narrow. The device must offer clear differentiation that players feel immediately, not just a spec sheet advantage. That could be better battery life, weight, haptics, or display. It also needs a software layer that solves real PC game headaches, from controller mapping to shader pre-caching to one click performance profiles per title. Cross-platform compatibility helps if it reduces time to library, but it cannot come at the cost of polish. Parallel investment in brand building and support infrastructure is not optional. Exclusivity still moves hardware, whether through smaller, tightly scoped indie partnerships, smart licensing, or content that uses unique hardware features. Serving niches like accessibility or repairability can also help build loyalty. ■